

MYTH #25: WOMEN AREN'T VERY GOOD GAMERS

Women gamers have conquered the highest peaks of competitive esports

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Right from Pong till Prey, the narrative of gender disparity in skills has been a stubborn myth, insinuating that women are somehow inherently less adept at gaming than their male counterparts. This couldn't be further from the truth, as I spotlight the remarkable achievements and skills of female gamers who are pushing the boundaries and setting new high scores.

Liooon

Li "Liooon" Xiaomeng is a professional Hearthstone player from China who has made a significant impact in esports. She has been playing for the team Victory Key E-Club since 2019. Her Battle.net name "VKLiooon" is a combination of her team's name "VK" and a deliberate misspelling of "Lion". Interestingly, her own Chinese name

translates to "cute" in modern Mandarin Chinese, influenced by Japanese comics culture¹². In 2019, Liooon won the Hearthstone Grandmasters Global Finals, which marked a turning point for female players in esports. She defeated Luna Eason (Bloodyface, representing the United States) to become the Hearthstone Global Champion, claiming a prize of \$200,000 (USD). With this achievement, she became the first woman to win a BlizzCon Esports tournament and the first Hearthstone Global Champion from mainland China.

After her historic victory, Liooon shared a story about her early experiences in esports where she was discouraged by a male player who told her that esports was not for women. She has since used her platform to encourage women in esports, stating: "I want to say for all the girls out there

who have a dream for Esports competition, for glory, if you want to do it and you believe in yourself, you should just forget your gender and go for it," she said at the time.

Since then, Liooon continued to compete in various tournaments. In 2020, she placed 5th-8th in the Hearthstone All-Star Invitational and the Masters Tour 2020 Los Angeles, and 6th-8th in the Masters Tour 2020.

HelloKittyRicki

Ricki Ortiz, also known as HelloKittyRicki, is an American professional fighting game player who specializes in the Marvel vs. Capcom and Street Fighter series. Born on December 12, 1981, Ortiz has been a prominent figure in the fighting game community since the early 2000s. Ortiz's interest in fighting games started in childhood when her father brought her to a Golfand Entertainment Center in Milpitas, California. By middle school, she was spending time at the local arcade almost every day after school. In 2001, she left the San Francisco Bay Area for the first time to compete in a major